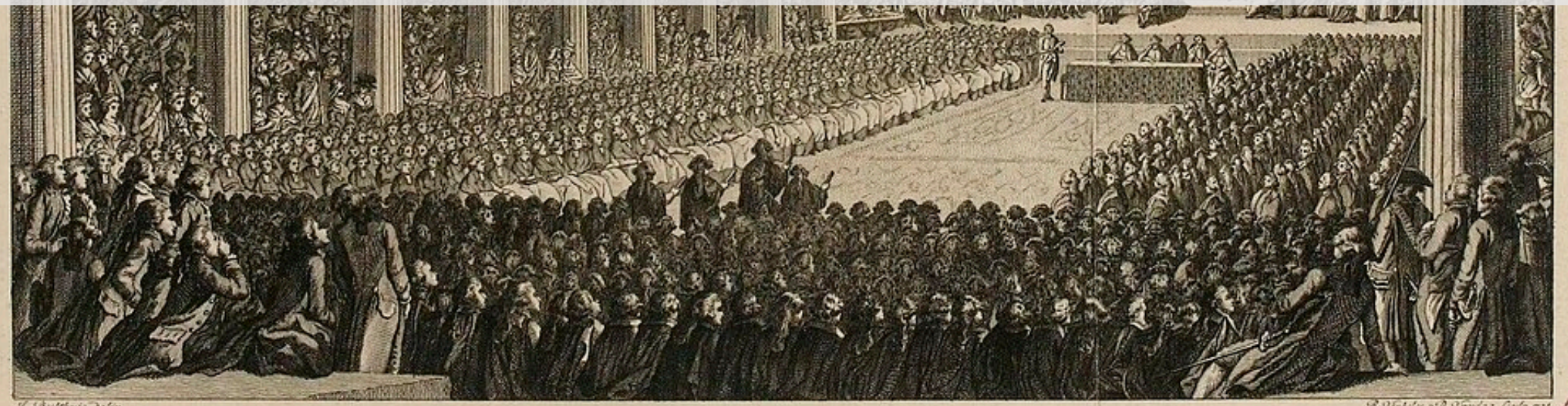


# The Logic of Political Parties

## Guest Lecture #4 (Mr. Wetsel)

THE UNIVERSITY OF ALABAMA AT BIRMINGHAM



# Agenda

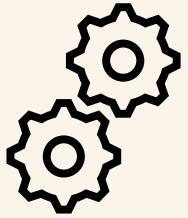
1

**Knowledge Check**



2

**Underlying Mechanisms**



3

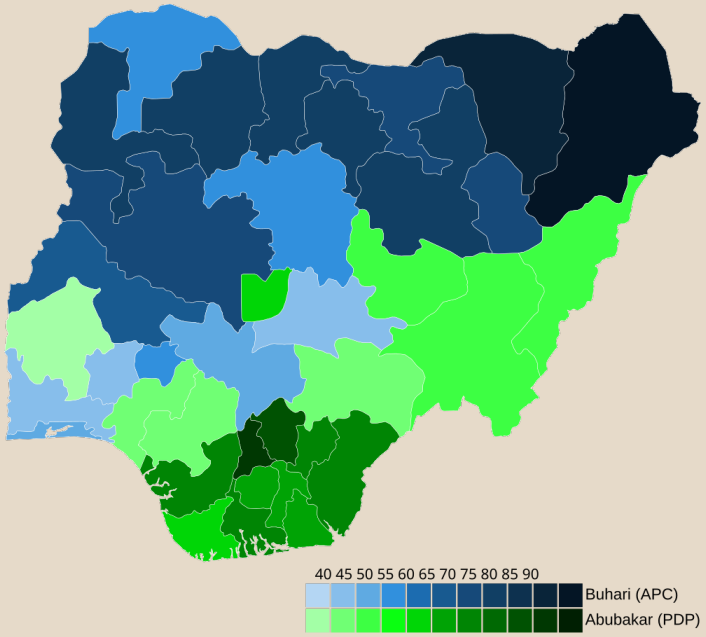
**Going Forward**



# Part I. Knowledge Check

# ***What*** is a political party and ***Why*** do democracies have them?






*A dual, complementary basis…*

Ontology ⇔ Teleology

# *A dual, complementary basis…*

## Ontology

Thus, whilst ontology is defined, literally, as the 'science' or 'philosophy' of being, within political analysis it has tended to be defined in more narrow and specific terms. Norman Blaikie's definition is here representative. Ontology, he suggests, "refers to the claims or assumptions that a particular approach to social [or, by extension, political] enquiry makes about the nature of social [or political] reality—claims about what exists, what it looks like, what units make it up and how these units interact with one another" (1993, 6). Ontology relates to *being*, to what *is*, to what *exists*, to the constituent units of reality; political ontology, by extension, relates to *political being*, to what *is* politically, to what *exists politically*, and to the units that comprise political reality.

# *A dual, complementary basis…*

## Ontology

What is the polity made of? What are its constituents and how do they hang together? What kinds of general principles govern its functioning, and its change? Are they causal principles and, if so, what is the nature of political causation? What drives political actors and what mental capacities do they possess? Do individual preferences and social institutions exist, and in what sense? Are (any of) these things historically and culturally invariant universals, or are they relative to context?

Such questions readily establish a simple analytical agenda for political ontology. They also serve to indicate that no political analysis can proceed in the absence of assumptions about political ontology. That such assumptions are rarely explicit hardly makes them less consequential. Presented more thematically, amongst the ontological issues on which political analysts formulate consequential assumptions are the following:

1. The relationship between structure and agency, context, and conduct.
2. The extent of the causal and/or constitutive role of ideas in the determination of political outcomes.
3. The extent to which social and political systems exhibit organic qualities or are reducible in all characteristics to the sum of their constituent units/parts.
4. The (dualistic or dialectical) relationship between mind and body.
5. The nature of the human (political) subject and its behavioural motivations.
6. The extent to which causal dynamics are culturally/contextually specific or generalizable.
7. The respective characteristics of the objects of the natural and social sciences.
8. Perhaps most fundamentally of all, the extent (if any) of the separation of appearance and reality—the extent to which the social and political world presents itself to us as really it is such that what is real is observable.

# *A dual, complementary basis…*

Teleology

OED | Oxford English Dictionary

Chiefly *Philosophy*.

**1.** The branch of knowledge or study dealing with ends or final causes; the study of phenomena which may be explained in terms of intention, design, or purposiveness rather than by prior causes. **1742–**

# *A dual, complementary basis…*

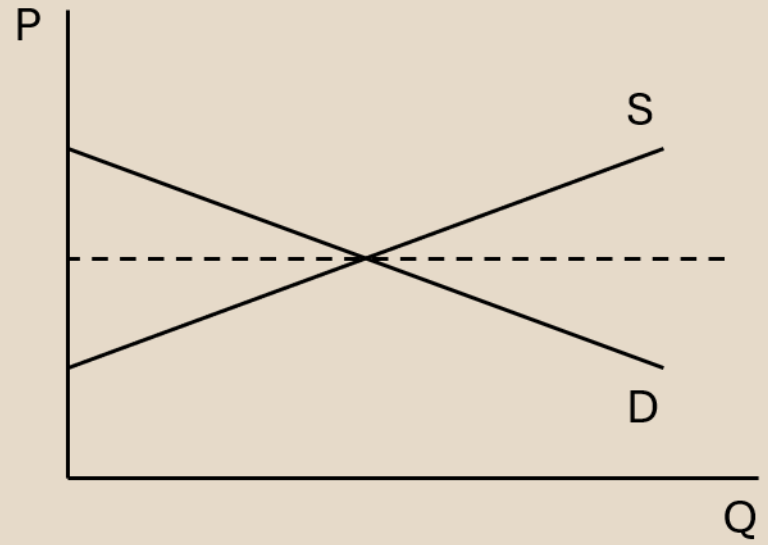
*The utilitarian principle*

Bentham offers his legislator both a goal and a mountain of advice for meeting that goal. The goal is the *utilitarian principle*, or the *greatest happiness principle*. The legislator's job is to use her knowledge of human nature to design laws that maximize the happiness of her people. (Bentham often uses the technical term "utility". This word can mean different things in English. Bentham's meaning is approximately equivalent to "instrumental for happiness".

Teleology

*A dual, complementary basis…*

# Supply & Demand



# Part I. Knowledge Check (RECAP)

# Part II. Underlying Mechanisms

# Preference Aggregation: A Collective Action Problem



# Preference Aggregation: A Collective Action Problem

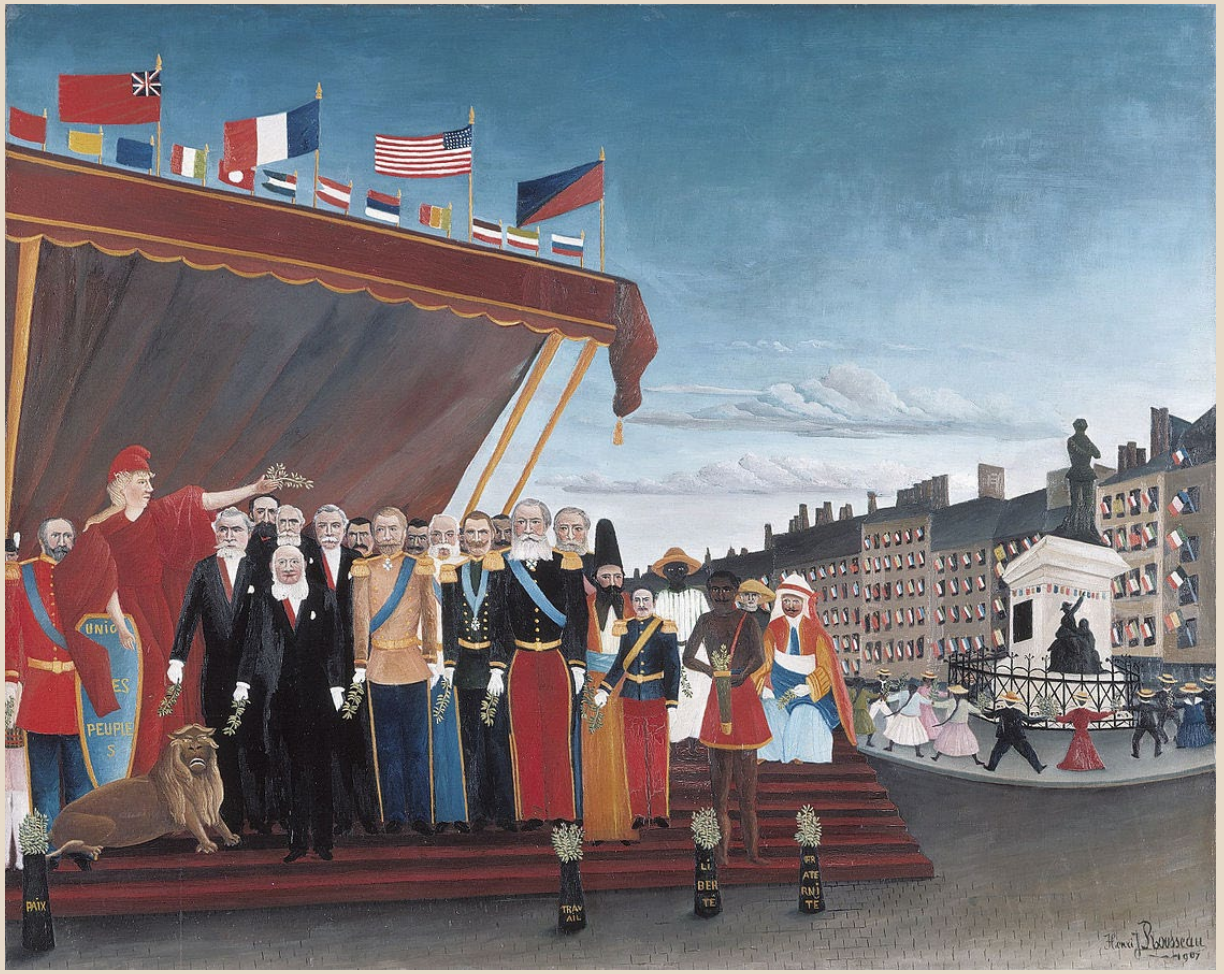


Public Goods Theory
- RCT Assumptions
- Non-Excludable & Non-Rivalrous
- Free Rider Problem
- +/- Externalities

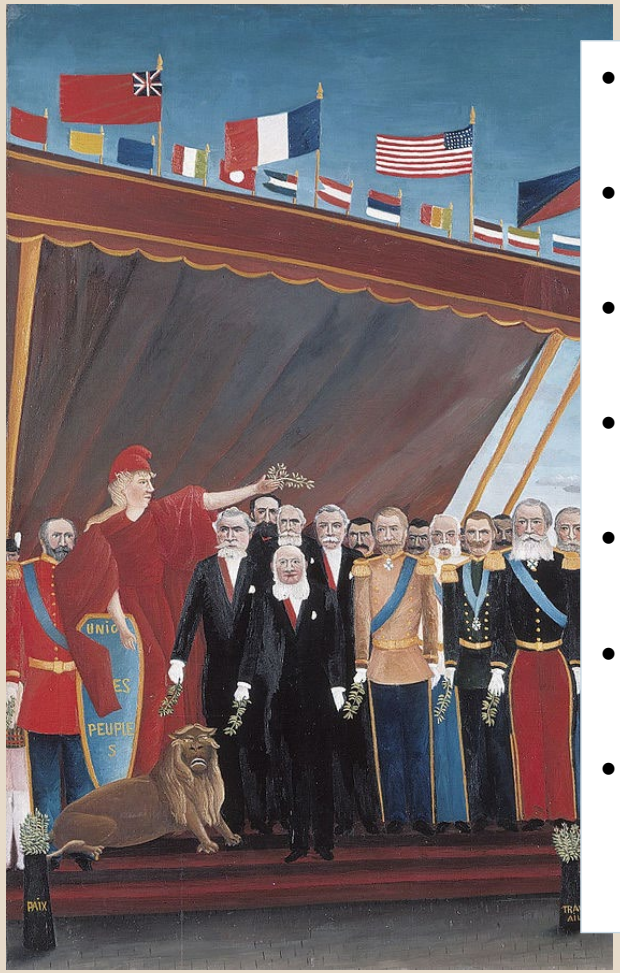
Rational Ignorance
- Opportunity Cost of Information
- Probability of Being the ‘Decisive Vote’

Asymmetric Information
- Credible Signaling
- Stated vs. Revealed Preferences
- Recency Bias

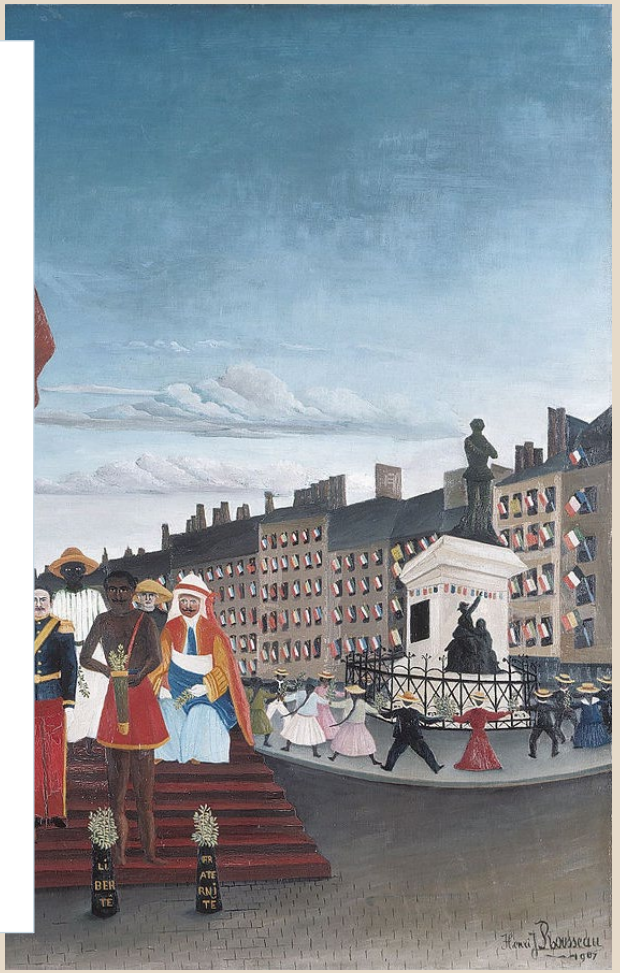
# Delegating Authority: A Principal Agent Problem



# Delegating Authority: A Principal Agent Problem



- Moral Hazard
- Adverse Selection
- Credible Enforcement of the ‘Political Contract’
- Delegates vs. Trustees
- Multiple Principals
- CBDC
- Shirking and Reneging



# Part II. Underlying Mechanisms (RECAP)

# Part III. Going Forward

# The Duality Principle of Representative Government




coincidentia oppositorum

# The Duality Principle of Representative Government

De Jure / De Facto

Centripetal /Centrifugal

coincidentia oppositorum

# Part III. Going Forward (RECAP)

# Thank You!